

GIMP TWEAKS

It's the holidays! Besides gifts, that means boatloads of photographs. In case you want to give a professional finish to the photographs, but don't want to sell your kidney to get the software, Gimp comes to your rescue. It gives the other biggies in the segment a run for their money. With loads of functionality and customisations up for grabs. Here are a few tricks to make your life easier.

Batch process your images with Gimp

Gimp doesn't have batch processing built into the core software. A simple batch processing plug-in DBP (David's Batch Processor) allows the user to automatically perform operations (such as resize, blur, sharpen) on a collection of image files. This plug-in is included in this month's Alpha DVD. Just copy the executable file and place it under `GIMP_INSTALLATION_FOLDER\lib\gimp\2.0\plug-ins`. Now restart Gimp. You'll find Batch Processing listed in the Filters menu. Clicking on Batch Processing will bring up the DBP dialog box. The mechanics are simple, each tab stands for one operation — select input files, enable the operations you'd like to perform and fine-tune the respective settings. Select output file type and parameters and you're done. There's one

catch here though, the default directory for output is same as the current working directory, hence you'll have to change the output directory with the "Select Dir" button in the Rename tab.

Colour correcting your photographs

Many times, you'll come across an image with a colour cast i.e. the picture is evenly affected by a tint of a particular colour. One of the main problems in dealing with such photographs is that we don't know which colour to correct. One of the solution is to target an area of the image that



An image afflicted by Jaundice



After colour correction

should be white (but isn't), for example, the white of the eyes or a wall which should be white. If there aren't any white areas in the image take the most neutral (grey) area of the image and in case you have no grey areas, go

with the actual color values, for instance skin tone should be a balanced magenta and yellow with cyan being 10-15 per cent of that value.

Select the Color Picker Tool (O) and click the area which should be white but isn't. In our case, it's the flowers that should be white. Now, click on the Foreground Color box to get the color selection dialog. Here, set the Saturation(S) to 100 and Value(V) to 60. Create a new layer and fill it with foreground color. With the new layer selected go to **Color > Invert**. Once this is done change its blend mode to Overlay. We're not quite done yet. You'll get another color cast, in this case the photo has acquired a bluish tinge. To counter this, lower the opacity of the foreground color layer till you get desired result. The value of opacity depends on the image you're working on.

Note that this method quickly removes color casts but it isn't the only way to colour correct over all channels. Use Levels and Curves for better control and more effective color correction.

Instagram without iPhone, really?

Named App of the Year for 2011 by Apple, Instagram lets you apply filters to photographs and publish them to social networks. Gimp plug-ins (akin to Photoshop actions) make your photos look as if they were



Picture before using Vintage plug-in

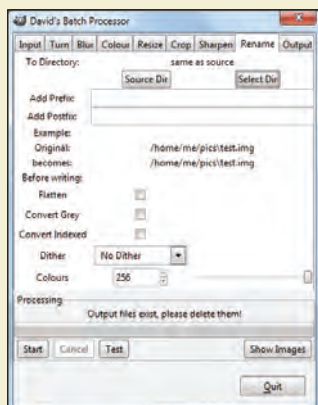


Kitty has gone vintage

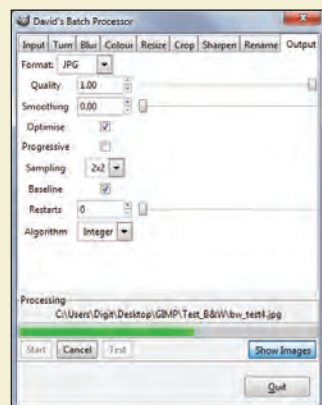
processed by Instagram. Two of the more famous filters are Lomo and Vintage. You will find these two and many other plug-ins in this month's Alpha DVD. To install them first find the folder where plug-ins are stored. You can find this folder by navigating to **Edit > Preferences > Folders > Scripts**. Once the folder is identified, just place .scm plug-in file from the DVD into that folder. Refresh the script library by going to **Filters > Script-Fu > Refresh Scripts** and you're done.

You'll find the plug-in(s) listed under the Filters menu. Once installed, Lomo can be applied by navigating to **Fil-**

ters > Light and Shadow > Lomo... and Vintage is found at **Filters > Artistic > Vintage Look**. On selecting the menu item a dialog will pop up letting you control some aspects of the scripts, you'll need to experiment with different set-



Change the output directory from Rename tab



Batch processing in progress



Changing the opacity of the overlay layer